consideration of the defence of British India, an idea of a great circle of security, continental and oceanic, radiating from the then India, surrounded by buffer states on the landward frontiers, the seas securely held by the Royal Navy and overall in latter days the mantle of airpower. It dated from a period when maintenance of the security of India was a ruling principle of every British government and it was developed as part of the world order enforced during the century of the Pax Britannica.' [65] The British had, in some ways, operationalized Kautilya's mandalas even if British officers were unfamiliar with the *Arthashastra*.

Like British policymakers, modern Indian strategists have consistently spoken of India's abiding strategic interest – economic and defence – in the Gulf and the Middle East. In 1944 Hriday Nath Kunzru, a member of the Indian National Congress, wrote that India's importance to the global community lay in her geostrategic location and large military and economic resources.[66] According to Panikkar, 'The Indian Ocean area together with Afghanistan, Sinkiang and Tibet as the outer northern ring constitute the real security of India. Geographically also this is one strategic unit, with India as its great air and land centre and as the base and arsenal of its naval power. From the central triangle of India the whole area can be controlled and defended.'[67]

It is under British colonial influence that India's neighbourhood is deemed to stretch from the Gulf and East Coast of Africa to South-East Asia. Indian strategists often seem to agree with Caroe's assertion that it is 'impossible' to visualize the Gulf unless that prism includes India which 'stands at the centre of the Ocean that bears its name'. [68] Modern India has always seen itself as a key player in the Middle East. Even before Independence, Nehru built close ties with his peers in Egypt and Turkey and reached out to Arab and Persian politicians and intellectuals.

Unlike the British era, independent India did not base its ties across the region through military prowess. Nehru did not like military alliances and